

Chapter 160-1

The wedding that seemed like a joke became a topic of conversation for the wealthy elites for a long time.

It wasn't as if this kind of thing—a younger sister substituting in marriage—had never happened before.

In arranged marriages, there was always bound to be someone who was disliked.

When the family patriarch particularly doted on a certain child, and the marriage partner wasn't valued, cases of pushing an unfavored daughter out as a substitute bride were everywhere. It wasn't big news.

But those were all done secretly.

The two families would discuss it, find some excuse to swap the marriage partner, and no one would know.

When people talked about it afterward, they would at most laugh a little. There wasn't much discussion value—it wasn't as interesting as chatting about entertainment industry gossip.

But the situation between Shen Fenghe and Gu Yixue was different.

Going to substitute at the wedding venue itself, especially when Gu Chunmian was still wearing a wedding dress and appeared on the red carpet, only to stand Shen Fenghe up right when they were about to get married.

Who didn't know that Shen Fenghe was famously capable and shrewd?

Shen Fenghe's father was named Shen Yaobo. Under his leadership, the Shen family rose to a higher level. The original Shen family actually couldn't compare to the Gu family—after all, the Gu family had a century-old foundation. They had successfully transformed from the heavy industry era, riding the tides of time with ancestral blessings protecting them.

The Shen family was slightly inferior.

But under Shen Yaobo's hands, the Shen family forcefully rose to equal status with the Gu family. It was from then that the phrase "Twin Heroes of Haizhou" came about.

When the family enterprise was passed down to Shen Fenghe, she managed to surpass the Gu family.

It had to be said that the younger generation of the Gu family was disappointing—not a single one could take on major responsibilities. The patriarch's most beloved grandchild was Gu Chunmian, but she was just a pretty face. As she grew older, she turned into a hopeless romantic¹. Once she turned twenty, she said she wanted to marry the one she loved and even eloped with her lover once.

And that so-called lover of hers had once taken ten million to break up with her.

Later, when that person fell on hard times, she returned to the country and came back to Gu Chunmian's side—and Gu Chunmian actually accepted her.

Gu Chunmian even got pregnant and brought her "true love" to the Gu family's door to force them into accepting the marriage, nearly making the old master of the Gu family faint from anger.

Even so, the Gu family still didn't give up on Gu Chunmian.

Abortion wasn't allowed domestically, so the Gu family took Gu Chunmian abroad to find a private doctor to terminate the pregnancy. Gu Chunmian caused quite a fuss over this, but she couldn't win against them.

The arm couldn't twist against the thigh².

She had to rely on the Gu family to be the Gu family's eldest daughter, to be Gu Chunmian.

If she left the Gu family, she didn't have a single survival skill—she would be nothing but a stray dog.

So over the years, the Gu family couldn't suppress her, and she couldn't persuade the Gu family.

They remained at this stalemate until now.

The Gu family had other direct descendants, and there were plenty waiting to inherit the family business, but they were all good-for-nothings with no promise.

One of them was even caught meeting up with a celebrity, then got blackmailed by the minor celebrity in a honey trap³.

At that time, it was Shen Fenghe who helped suppress the matter.

None of the younger generation of the Gu family could be presentable.

Oh, except for Gu Yixue.

But who would have thought that the only promising one among the Gu family's grandchildren was actually the Gu family's illegitimate daughter—Gu Yixue.

That ordinary Beta whose mother, when she was dying, brought her to kneel outside the Gu family's main gate for two days and two nights, got drenched in rain for two nights, and nearly died from a high fever.

Because of evolutionary differences, Betas couldn't smell Alpha and Omega pheromones and weren't affected by them. Correspondingly, their physical constitution was generally not as good as Alphas and Omegas.

In this world, most geniuses were Alphas or Omegas.

But as it happened, Gu Yixue was just a Beta.

An ordinary Beta.

However, Gu Yixue's appearance and intelligence both met the standards of an Alpha or Omega.

That little girl who nearly died in the rainy night and through countless humiliations went abroad at sixteen and eventually amazed the entire world under the name "Quella."

She was a Chinese person who made a name for herself in a place teeming with foreigners.

The achievements she obtained moved the entire entertainment industry.

Even though these elite circles looked down on the entertainment industry, they were all aware of the developments within it.

So at that time, many people said that the Gu family might look upon Gu Yixue more favorably.

But unexpectedly, Gu Yixue remained the most marginalized person in the Gu family.

The Gu family still stubbornly tried to save that hopeless case⁴.

Because Gu Chunmian was the legitimate one.

Gu Yixue was just an illegitimate daughter—lowly and cheap.

These were the words Gu's father had used to curse Gu Yixue's mother, which were overheard by someone with ulterior motives and spread around, causing quite a controversy.

Gu Yixue never cared.

Since she dared to walk through that door wearing a wedding dress, she had prepared for everything.

Even if there was a cliff ahead, she could stride forward without hesitation.

How many times can a person be brave for themselves?

Perhaps only once.

At that day's wedding banquet, hardly anyone could eat. Only Gu Yixue and Shen Fenghe, the two parties involved, ate their fill as if nothing had happened.

Liang Shi followed beside Gu Yixue and barely managed to get a meal, but everyone around her wasn't touching their chopsticks much, so she felt too embarrassed to eat either.

Halfway through the meal, Shen Hui came over to find her, asking what exactly was going on. Why did Gu Yixue come to crash the wedding?

Liang Shi was stunned, then said hesitantly: "This is probably called... filling in?"

Shen Hui: "....."

What the hell, filling in.

"Why are you with her?" Shen Hui asked. "In other words, why would you become her accomplice?"

Liang Shi: ".....She's my friend."

"Fine," Shen Hui said. "That's quite....."

Before she could finish her assessment, a crisp voice called out from behind: "Miss Liang, Ah Hui."

Liang Shi looked up—it was the aunt who had been sitting at the main table earlier, and also the aunt she had encountered at the museum restroom entrance that day. If she remembered correctly, her name should be Zhu Mingqi?

Liang Shi roughly understood now—this was Shen Hui's mother.

It was quite a coincidence, when you thought about it.

She had met the members of the Shen family at different times.

First Shen Hui, then Shen Siyan, then Shen Fenghe, then Zhu Mingqi. Aside from Mr. Shen, she had gathered the complete set of the Shen family.

Footnotes:

¹ **Hopeless romantic (戀愛腦)**: Literally "romance brain" - a Chinese internet slang term describing someone who prioritizes romantic love above all else, often making irrational decisions for the sake of love.

² **The arm couldn't twist against the thigh (胳膊擰不過大腿)**: A Chinese idiom meaning the weak cannot prevail against the strong; one cannot fight against those more powerful than oneself.

³ **Honey trap (仙人跳)**: Literally "immortal jump" - a type of scam/blackmail scheme in Chinese, typically where someone is lured into a compromising situation (usually romantic or sexual) and then extorted.

⁴ **Hopeless case (扶不起來的阿鬥)**: A Chinese idiom referring to Liu Shan (nicknamed "A Dou"), the incompetent son of Liu Bei from the Three Kingdoms period. The phrase describes someone who cannot be helped no matter how much support they receive—a lost cause.

Chapter 160-2

Liang Shi politely greeted the other party: "Auntie Zhu."

While speaking, her gaze swept over a few more times, especially at her eyes.

But clearly, Zhu Mingqi's eyes didn't resemble Shen Hui's or Shen Fenghe's.

However, the scene had been so chaotic earlier that she hadn't had the time or mind to look at Mr. Shen's eyes.

These children of theirs must all take after Mr. Shen.

"Little Liang." Zhu Mingqi smiled warmly, seemingly unaffected by the farce at Shen Fenghe's wedding. "Did you know Ah Hui before?"

Liang Shi nodded: "We've met a few times by chance."

Shen Hui was also surprised: "Mom, how do you know her?"

Zhu Mingqi smiled. "I happened to meet her once at the art museum. This young lady and you are quite....."

Her words suddenly stopped midway, because she remembered that Liang Shi was already married.

There was no way to match her with her daughter anymore.

Zhu Mingqi sighed and changed the subject: "Look at this—Miss Liang is already married. What about you? You don't even have a partner."

Shen Hui: "....."

"Oh." Shen Hui said sarcastically, "I even know her wife, so what?"

Zhu Mingqi secretly pinched her. "Keep causing trouble."

Then she looked at Liang Shi: "I'm sorry, Miss Liang. My daughter has been spoiled and doesn't know any better."

Shen Hui: "?"

Liang Shi was flattered and quickly waved her hands: "It's fine, it's fine."

It was only at this moment that she realized—if Zhu Mingqi was Shen Hui's mother, then she was Madam Shen?

A connection far beyond her reach.

She hadn't expected Madam Shen to be so approachable. Liang Shi inexplicably felt a sense of warmth toward her.

"I saw you came with Little Gu," Zhu Mingqi said. "You're Director Gu's friend, right?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes, I acted in Director Gu's production before."

Zhu Mingqi was surprised: "Which one? Has Little Gu filmed something new? How come I haven't seen it? I've watched all her previous works. Did you play a minor role? But with your face, that shouldn't be the case."

Liang Shi didn't know whether to laugh or cry, unsure whether to thank Zhu Mingqi for the compliment or to be humble.

"No." Liang Shi could only tell the truth. "We filmed Director Gu's new movie. It hasn't been released yet."

"I see." Zhu Mingqi said, "Then when it's released, Auntie will book out the theater and bring lots of people to watch."

Liang Shi: "Okay."

She had never seen someone of Zhu Mingqi's status be so pleasant to someone who was still practically a stranger.

She was truly flattered—to the point of internally exclaiming "I don't deserve this."

Yet Liang Shi still carried herself with grace and poise, responding politely to all her questions.

Until—

Zhu Mingqi suddenly asked: "Miss Liang, is your mother Qiu Zimin?"

Liang Shi paused, then slowly nodded: "Yes. Why?"

"Nothing." Zhu Mingqi smiled, though the smile was somewhat cold. "Your mother was once my friend too."

Liang Shi: "....."

That word "once" was used so perfectly.

Although everyone at home knew she and Qiu Zimin had fallen out, they hadn't announced it to the outside world.

Liang Shi had no intention of publicizing these matters in front of outsiders, so she naturally gave a casual response.

However, she had seen Su Zhe at this wedding but hadn't seen Liang Xinzhou.

According to business logic, the two held similar positions.

Yet no one from the Liang family had appeared.

This meant they hadn't received an invitation.

If the Shen family hadn't invited these people, why would Su Zhe be here?

Liang Shi had been pondering this earlier, and now she seemed to catch a glimpse of something, though it was still vague.

"Your mother is a person of temperament," Zhu Mingqi remarked.

Liang Shi smiled in response: "You flatter her."

They chatted casually for a bit more after that, but Liang Shi answered everything with some trepidation.

She didn't know when Zhu Mingqi's attitude had shifted—probably the moment she confirmed that Liang Shi was Qiu Zimin's daughter.

"Once" friends meant they weren't anymore.

Had they fallen out?

And Qiu Zimin had never mentioned knowing anyone from the Shen family.

After they left, Liang Shi conducted a brainstorming session in her mind and suddenly had a very bold, very presumptuous guess—

Chapter 160-3

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The guess was never verified.

Liang Shi didn't have any personal belongings from anyone in the Shen family.

Gu Yixue was newly married, but if she were to rudely ask, "Director Gu, could you give me a toothbrush that Shen Fenghe has used? Or give me a strand of Shen Fenghe's hair."

She would probably be seen by Gu Yixue as having some kind of fetish.

Or Gu Yixue would figure it out in less than a minute.

Making guesses was one thing, but planning to do a DNA test was another matter entirely.

The former might be fantasy; the latter would be blatant freeloading¹.

Yet the logical chain in between seemed to form a closed loop.

Qiu Zimin, because she had become enemies with Zhu Mingqi, after her own daughter was stolen, went and stole Zhu Mingqi's daughter, then raised her daughter under her wing, turning her into a deviant as revenge.

But the problem was that everyone in the Shen family thought that child had died.

It was a premature death, not a disappearance.

So no one suspected that Liang Shi could be a child of the Shen family.

Actually, Liang Shi herself shouldn't suspect either—after all, Shen Fenghe had solemnly said her younger sister had died young. But the countless times people mentioned her similar eye color, and the fact that she wasn't Qiu Zimin's biological child, made her unable to resist suspecting.

Especially since Zhu Mingqi said she knew Qiu Zimin.

The truth seemed to be right before her eyes.

But Liang Shi had no choice but to give up because she couldn't get their personal belongings.

She actually didn't want to search for her birth family.

Being alone like this was fine too.

Just like Liang Xinran²—although she had searched for her family and found her biological parents, the lost years were still lost. She was already this old and had long developed the habit of being independent. She didn't lack money or love; she wasn't at an age where she absolutely needed to find her parents.

Returning to acknowledge relatives would inevitably cause a huge commotion, like throwing a stone into a calm, still lake—it would create layer upon layer of ripples.

Liang Shi felt it would be very awkward.

She would resist from the very beginning any environment that made her feel at a loss.

After accompanying Gu Yixue to crash the wedding and achieving a pretty good result, Liang Shi's days afterward were uneventful.

A few days later, her agent called her to participate in a variety show—the kind where you make appearances on regular variety shows to gain exposure.

Because she didn't have a representative work yet, and her only work was the red outfit look that had gone viral before, they asked if she could dance. They wanted to arrange a mid-show performance slot for her, just wearing red—either in ancient costume or modern attire would be fine.

This variety show aired weekly with high public recognition and national popularity. This time, a slot had opened up entirely because a senior from their company had let it go. It was originally that senior's spot, but because she had temporarily joined a production—a big director's drama—she couldn't be bothered with this kind of exposure variety show anymore.

Actually, once you went in, you might not even get three lines—one self-introduction, a short supporting performance, one "thank you," one "goodbye."

Whether even those three lines would make the final cut was uncertain.

But for a newcomer, this opportunity was a pretty good resource.

When the time came, they could buy a hot search³, and it would be easier to find drama and movie resources for Liang Shi.

Because Liang Shi's face was more refined and better suited for the big screen, her agent wanted her to star in movies, heading straight for the goal of "Box Office Queen." Plus, with her role in Gu Yixue's movie, once "Heart's Journey" was released, it might be a double harvest of reputation and box office. Then she wouldn't be considered without works.

Even if she couldn't win Best Actress, getting an international nomination for Best Newcomer definitely wouldn't be a problem.

The agent had planned her path very well, so when she came to ask, she used a very firm tone, with an implication of "you must participate."

However, Liang Shi could also refuse.

This agent was similar to Sister Wang—she wouldn't force you to do anything, and she would give you opportunities, but if you didn't seize them, sorry, there wouldn't be a next time.

Back when Liang Shi first joined the company, Sister Wang also had several newcomers under her. But Liang Shi was the most talented, the least picky about work, and the best at seizing opportunities—unlike many newcomers who had just entered the entertainment industry, who were particularly impetuous and wanted big directors and good roles right from the start.

Liang Shi would only choose what was most advantageous to herself within an appropriate range.

So Liang Shi understood the agent's underlying message. Without even asking what dance she would be doing or how many days of rehearsal there would be, she accepted without hesitation.

The agent smiled with satisfaction and only then explained the time, location, and collaboration partners clearly.

There was one day of rehearsal time. Since it would be with three other artists from their company, those three would be promoting their new song while she was an extra member. The dance was in a Chinese traditional style, and she needed to learn fan dancing.

Fan dancing involved relatively difficult movements, including several high-difficulty aerial spins that would be performed by the center position among the four. Liang Shi wouldn't have much focus on her.

The agent specifically emphasized this.

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "Got it, I'll cherish this opportunity."

The agent also reminded her: "Don't steal too much of the spotlight."

Liang Shi knew this too and immediately agreed, "Understood."

The former was the agent testing her reaction—to see if she lacked self-awareness, thinking that being on stage meant she'd get lots of solo shots, and that she could go viral across the internet just with a set of amazing photos like before.

The latter was because the agent saw she didn't have those messy ulterior motives, so she gave her this advice.

In this industry, don't offend seniors who aren't very famous yet, especially those in the same company who haven't made it big.

The gun shoots the bird that sticks its head out⁴.

Liang Shi deeply understood this principle.

She roughly knew what level the agent wanted her to maintain.

The recording was in two days, and she only had one day of rehearsal. Everyone else had already practiced on their own and just needed to run through formations a few times. Liang Shi was undoubtedly behind.

The agent sent her a video and told her to practice first. Tomorrow, a car would pick her up and take her to the dance studio.

It would be best if she could directly join the others in formation practice.

Once Liang Shi got the video, she threw herself into practice.

She was still staying at Zhao Xuning's place and didn't really want to move out and face an empty house alone.

Liang Shi casually tied her hair into a fluffy bun.

There were T-shirts in the closet. She changed into a white one, and because there were wave movements, she rolled up the hem of her shirt, exposing the abs on her abdomen, and tied up the side with a small hair tie.

For pants, she wore comfortable black joggers, placed a yoga mat under her feet, and practiced facing the mirror.

She didn't have a dance background, but she had played an ancient dancer before, so she had done a crash course with a teacher previously and knew a little bit.

However, she was quite skilled with fans, because she had played a martial arts hero. A folding fan would fly out, and when it flew back, the tip of the fan would be stained with a layer of blood. Normally, she had to spin the fan—not only spin it fast but also make it look good.

At the most extreme, she had spun the fan for three consecutive days, to the point where the moment her hand held a fan, she would subconsciously spin it.

Footnotes:

¹ **Blatant freeloading (碰瓷兒):** A Chinese slang term originally referring to a scam where someone deliberately gets hit by a car or breaks something to extort money. Here it's used more broadly to mean taking advantage of someone or making unfounded claims to benefit from a situation—in this case, trying to claim family ties without solid evidence.

² **Liang Xinran:** Note that the original text uses "梁欣然" which appears to be the same character mentioned in the translation guidelines as "郭欣然 = Guo Xinran." However, the character here is written with the surname "Liang" (梁) in the original, which may be a typo or different character. Translation kept as written in original.

³ **Buy a hot search (買熱搜):** In Chinese social media (particularly Weibo), "hot searches" are trending topics. Entertainment companies often pay to get their artists' names or related topics onto the trending list to increase exposure.

⁴ **The gun shoots the bird that sticks its head out (槍打出頭鳥):** A Chinese proverb meaning that those who stand out or draw attention to themselves will be targeted. It advises against being too conspicuous or showing off.

Chapter 160-4

After watching this dance, Liang Shi found that the fan movements involved were all relatively simple.

But dancing with props and dancing without props were completely different. To avoid dragging everyone else down, she still needed to practice her part thoroughly with the fan.

However, there were no fans at Zhao Xuning's place, so Liang Shi messaged Zhao Xuning: 【Can you bring back a fan when you come home?】

Zhao Xuning: 【...Your room has air conditioning. The remote is in the bedside drawer.】

Liang Shi: 【No, I need a fan for practicing martial arts.】

Zhao Xuning: 【?】

Liang Shi: 【Correction: dance.】

Zhao Xuning: 【??】

When Zhao Xuning came back, she had still bought a fan, then stood at the doorway of the room staring at Liang Shi.

Her stare made Liang Shi feel a bit embarrassed, and she couldn't quite continue practicing her dance.

"Go do your own thing, don't worry about me," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning said: "I'm just watching."

"What's there to watch? You'll be able to see it on TV later anyway," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning stared at her abdomen, and after a long while said in a seemingly indifferent tone: "You actually have abs."

Liang Shi: "....."

She answered matter-of-factly: "What else would I have?"

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"I do two hundred crunches every day," Liang Shi said. "Besides, I make a living off my face and figure. If an actress can't keep up physically, she'll be at a disadvantage when delivering lines."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"I understand now." Zhao Xuning sneered. "You drag me to eat late-night snacks every day while secretly doing crunches yourself."

Liang Shi: "?"

Why did that sound so much like—"You cunning, treacherous villain"?

"No, listen to my explanation," Liang Shi said. "Eating is eating, but I really don't gain weight, right? As for doing crunches, that's my exercise habit. The abs are just something I casually developed."

Zhao Xuning: ".....Okay, got it."

Her face still had that expression of—"Go ahead and make things up, I'll just quietly watch you make things up."

Liang Shi felt she couldn't explain herself clearly, but Zhao Xuning didn't plan to keep watching either. She went back to her room, changed into workout clothes, and headed straight out the door.

Liang Shi leaned against the doorframe and asked: "Where are you going?"

Zhao Xuning didn't even turn her head: "The gym."

Liang Shi: "....."

Top students probably just couldn't stand losing at anything?

Liang Shi didn't understand, but she got it.

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The variety show Liang Shi was participating in was called "Happy Tropic"¹. The others performing with her were all from girl groups, all with idol faces.

Liang Shi stood out a bit among them.

However, she barely managed to keep up during the first run-through, and even her fan spinning was quite beautiful.

But anyone who could sign with Huayi wasn't bad.

During a break, she sat there by herself spinning the fan for fun, and the dance director saw her. He thought one of her movements was particularly beautiful and wanted to temporarily add it to the dance.

After changing that one, the dance director brought back the difficulty level he had previously reduced out of fear it was too high.

There was one move where you throw the fan high in the air, spin 360 degrees on the spot, then flick your sleeve and catch the fan backhanded. It would fit perfectly with a line in the song they were performing.

Originally this move was included, but because the difficulty was too high and none of these people were professional dancers, they had to abandon it.

But when done well, this move was especially impressive.

Now, after seeing Liang Shi, the dance director's hopes were reignited. He explained the key points of the move to Liang Shi and had her try it. On the first try, the fan fell to the ground, but on the second try, she could spin beautifully and catch the fan steadily.

Truly gifted.

The dance director wanted to temporarily adjust the positions, but Liang Shi deeply understood the implications and didn't agree.

She said quietly to the dance director: "The original focus of this dance is meant to highlight the three of them. This is their stage. It wouldn't be good for me to steal the spotlight like this. Besides, if the dance is too eye-catching, it will distract everyone's attention from the song, reducing what was originally a beautiful piece of music to mere background music. That's not good."

Hearing this, the dance director had no choice but to give up.

When rehearsal ended and everyone was about to go home, the group's leader said to Liang Shi: "You're amazing."

"Huh?" Liang Shi was surprised. "I just did what I was supposed to do."

"But that's already remarkable," the leader said. "Being able to step back for the sake of the work in front of a big stage is very admirable."

Liang Shi chuckled softly at this: "I guess that's an occupational habit of actors?"

The recording naturally went smoothly.

Although Liang Shi was a peripheral figure, her movements were fluid, her voice was pleasant, and especially in the red outfit, she was exceptionally stunning.

She especially had a certain quality about her.

The others were singing, while she was acting along with the lyrics.

Every look in her eyes was just right.

After their performance, the host said this was her "red outfit kill"² and was curious whether she could achieve the same red outfit effect no matter what she wore.

Liang Shi smiled and said: "Depends on the situation."

When she finally changed back into casual clothes, it felt like she had become a completely different person.

In any case, her first variety show recording went rather smoothly.

This episode would air next Friday evening, and it was a satellite TV variety show³.

Afterward, it would be simultaneously broadcast on the four major online platforms.

After finishing the variety show recording, Liang Shi went back to the company with the girl group. In the car, she listened to them chatting about the upheaval in upper management.

One of the girls said: "It's got nothing to do with me anyway. It's not like I'll ever meet the CEO."

Another said: "I heard the new CEO is a particularly beautiful female Alpha. An employee saw her come to the company—she's at the level where she could be pulled out as an artist and it wouldn't seem out of place."

"That good-looking?"

"Yeah."

"When is she coming again? I'll pretend to run into her by chance."

"You'd have better luck dreaming about it. I heard the contract has already been signed, and it's been her assistant coming all the times after that."

"What a shame. I was hoping to dream about becoming the CEO's wife."

"....."

They chatted for a while longer before shifting the topic to recently released dramas.

Liang Shi sat in the back row unable to join the conversation, nor did she have the mind to join in. She lowered her head and played mobile games on her phone.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Happy Tropic" (開心回歸線):** The show's name literally translates to "Happy Tropic/Return Line." "回歸線" refers to the Tropic of Cancer or Tropic of Capricorn in geography, but here it's used as part of a variety show name suggesting happiness and return/reunion.

² **"Red outfit kill" (紅衣殺):** Internet slang where "kill" (殺) is used to describe a look or moment that is so stunning it metaphorically "kills" (captivates/slays) the audience. "Red outfit kill" means looking devastatingly attractive in red clothing.

³ **Satellite TV variety show (衛視上星綜藝):** "上星" refers to programs that are broadcast via satellite, meaning they can be received nationwide rather than just locally. This indicates the show has significant reach and prestige.

Chapter 160-5

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The day after Liang Shi finished recording the show, she received a call from Gu Xingyue. She said she wanted to meet Feng Xian, but instructed Liang Shi not to tell Feng Xian beforehand.

After getting Zhao Xuning's consent, Liang Shi arranged a gathering and invited Feng Xian out under the pretense of wanting to consult about a script.

The meeting place was at a teahouse. Zhao Xuning, who wasn't on duty, came along as well.

Feng Xian was slender, with an elegant and refined air about her. She wasn't wearing glasses. Upon seeing Liang Shi, she gave a slight nod. "Hello."

Liang Shi greeted her: "Hello, Teacher."

Gu Xingyue arrived late. By the time she came, everyone had already been sitting there chatting for a while. When Liang Shi chatted with Feng Xian, she could tell this was someone with deep literary accomplishment.

Moreover, she wasn't condescending at all. She didn't look down on Liang Shi for being a graduate of a third-rate university just because she herself was a literature professor. Instead, she explained things very gently, even breaking them down into simple pieces for her to understand.

Liang Shi listened comfortably and attentively.

When Gu Xingyue came in, she first made eye contact with Feng Xian, and then both of them paused. After a long moment of looking at each other, they both smiled and said in unison: "So it's you."

They had met before at the hospital, though they had only exchanged one sentence.

It could also be considered a brief encounter.

Gu Xingyue sat across from her, quiet and well-behaved, not saying anything, just listening in silence.

When Feng Xian finished speaking, Gu Xingyue silently poured her another cup of tea.

Everyone had some pastries, then headed to a restaurant for a proper meal.

Zhao Xuning followed behind Feng Xian the whole way, very considerate.

During the meal, Gu Xingyue suddenly asked: "I heard you lost a daughter?"

Feng Xian was picking up food with her chopsticks when her hand trembled, and the food fell onto the table.

Feng Xian's lips quivered. It was clear that mentioning this was somewhat difficult for her to accept, but she still said: "Yes."

Just bringing it up made her voice choke.

Gu Xingyue placed some food into her bowl with her chopsticks. "Please don't get too emotional."

"I'm not." Feng Xian smiled faintly. "It's been a long time since anyone brought up this topic with me."

That was why she had gotten emotional when she first heard it.

But after the emotion came an overwhelming sense of loss.

After so many years of searching, she had already given up.

Only a tiny sliver of hope remained in her heart to sustain her.

Gu Xingyue asked: "Then how did you lose your daughter?"

Feng Xian lowered her eyes, and a tear fell into her bowl. Her shoulders trembled slightly, but she still maintained her composure. "Her father had met some business friends back then and wanted to take her out to play. He said the other party also had a child. When they took them out, both children were stolen together."

As Feng Xian spoke, her hands clenched so hard that the veins on the back of her hands bulged.

"He just wanted to curry favor with those people." Feng Xian said, "If he hadn't taken our daughter out back then, my daughter wouldn't have been lost."

"Then..." Gu Xingyue paused briefly. "What about your husband?"

Feng Xian was stunned. After a long while, she sighed and said: "Dead. I divorced him because of what happened to our daughter. Not long after, his company went bankrupt and he jumped off a building."

"Have you been alone all these years?" Gu Xingyue asked.

Feng Xian nodded: "I've always wanted to find my daughter. I haven't had the heart to find another partner."

Gu Xingyue pressed her lips together and placed another serving of food into Feng Xian's bowl.

Feng Xian smiled faintly: "You don't need to pity me. All these years I've..."

Before she could finish, Gu Xingyue spoke up: "Then would you mind having another daughter?"

Feng Xian froze: "Huh?"

"I should be the daughter you lost many years ago." Gu Xingyue said as calmly as she could. "Our blood types are the same, and we produce rejection reactions¹. Dr. Zhao helped us do a DNA test, so... I am your daughter."

Feng Xian looked at Zhao Xuning in confusion.

The sudden news hit her, and she was still somewhat at a loss.

It seemed like a very long time passed before Feng Xian slowly digested the news. Tears blurred her vision, and through the watery haze she looked at Gu Xingyue, raising her hand to touch Gu Xingyue's face. "So you really are my daughter?"

"Qianqian." Feng Xian called her childhood nickname. "Qianqian."

.....

Even Zhao Xuning, that cold and aloof person, got teary-eyed along with them.

It took a long time for the private room to calm down. Feng Xian kept holding Gu Xingyue's hand, looking at her with full maternal love.

Before long, Feng Xian began to tell the story of those past events.

Her ex-husband's surname was Gao. After his successful startup, he had always wanted to climb higher, saying he wanted to give her and their daughter a comfortable life.

But unexpectedly, their daughter was lost, his wife left, and his family fell apart.

The other child who was stolen at the same time was the daughter of another CEO they had gone out with, surnamed Liang.

As soon as Liang was mentioned, Zhao Xuning couldn't help but look at Liang Shi.

Feng Xian also noticed this. She looked at Liang Shi: "It shouldn't be your Liang, right? That person was called Liang Zu. His wife was much calmer than me. I even hit my husband at the time."

Liang Zu...

Liang Shi gave a light cough: "It's not me, but it is that Liang."

Feng Xian was surprised: "Huh?"

Liang Shi said: "I'm not the daughter who was lost. I was picked up by Liang Zu later."

"That little girl." Feng Xian suddenly said, then paused for a moment. "It wasn't Liang Zu who picked you up, was it? It was his wife. Back then, outside Shi'an Hospital, I saw someone throw you on the ground. A little while later, his wife went over and picked you up. At the time, you were already on the verge of death... your whole face was purple."

Liang Shi was stunned. She hadn't expected that some of what Qiu Zimin said was actually true.

"How... do you know?" Liang Shi asked.

Feng Xian smiled bitterly: "To be honest with you, I suspected Liang Zu had done something back then, so I followed his wife for a while. I only gave up after confirming that their child really was lost. That's when I happened to see her pick up a child. Later I heard she treated that child very well."

Liang Shi: "....."

Sure enough, Qiu Zimin had deceived so many people.

However...

Liang Shi asked: "Did you see who abandoned me?"

"No." Feng Xian said, "That person was wearing a white headscarf, sunglasses, and a mask. They looked very suspicious, so I suspected you were an abandoned baby."

Liang Shi: "....."

Zhao Xuning, who had been listening the whole time, suddenly spoke up. "The probability of an abandoned baby appearing at Shi'an Hospital... is very small."

Liang Shi: "?"

Zhao Xuning slowly continued: "Shi'an Hospital is a high-end private hospital. The mothers who give birth there are either rich or noble... So there's an eighty percent chance there wouldn't be an abandoned baby. It's very possible that at that time, you were a... stillborn?"

Liang Shi: "?"

"There's also the possibility that you were a stolen stillborn." Zhao Xuning suddenly stared directly into Liang Shi's eyes.

Footnotes:

¹ **Rejection reactions (排異反應):** In the context of this story, this refers to a medical phenomenon where blood or tissue from closely related individuals (such as parent and child) can produce specific immune reactions. This can be used as preliminary evidence of biological relationship before DNA testing confirms it.